

AETHER PEAKS

ASPIRANTS: KINDLED



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CRASH!



WE OPEN ON THE PARTY, RIDING A CABLE CAR across the valley between Stonehollow and Dimdale. They set off a day or two back, hiking across the mountains west of Stonehollow towards Dimdale, letters in hand, as Aspirants to the Ember Guard. Earlier this evening they boarded a cable car, planning on resting at the wayhouse on the far side.

There's a sudden snap. Not the groan of stressed metal, but the sharp, gut-deep crack of something vital giving way.

The floor tilts. Someone's gear slides across the planks. The world pitches backward.

For a heartbeat, you're weightless — and then the car begins to fall.

The cable screams against the mountainside, sparks bursting in the thin air. Fragments of ice and rock whip past. The wind roars louder than thought.

You have less than a minute before the impact. What do you do?

THE CABLE CAR

LAYOUT

- The interior is about 10x6 feet, and about 7 feet tall. Enough for 4-6 passengers and luggage.
- The exterior is made of wood banded with iron.
- A sliding door on either short side can be used to access the interior, and benches run along the two long sides to provide seating.
- Cargo netting and hooks line the walls and ceiling.
- A small hatch in the ceiling can be used to climb on top and access the line/pulley mechanisms.
- A hand-crank and brake-lever are situated in one corner, though both are intended for stabilization and docking, not high speed/emergency use.

FUNCTIONALITY

- The car is attached beneath the main iron tension cable, riding a mechanical trolley with two wheels and a powered grip system.
- It's drawn by arcane-tethered winches from each end station — synchronized through bound crystals that keep tension steady between peaks.
- A faint hum or low vibration runs through the floor when it's in motion — the sound of distant winches, amplified by the cable.
- Safety enchantments are minimal: runes to repel lightning and stabilize temperature, but nothing that could slow a catastrophic failure. Such are too rare, and often unsurvivable regardless.

MAINTENANCE/SAFETY

- Every few weeks, engineers run maintenance cars along the lines — open-frame platforms with inspection tools, grease, and arcane diagnostic lenses.
- Routine passengers often tie harness lines to the car's inner hooks — mostly habit, but sometimes lifesaving.
- The Stonehollow–Dimdale route is considered old but reliable... until now.
- Most locals have ridden one at least once; they respect them the way sailors respect old ships — with affection and a hint of superstition.

INITIAL JOLT

Call for a medium Might or Agility power roll to see how knocked around everyone gets.

- ≤ 11 - You are thrown across the compartment, losing hold of a piece of gear; what do you drop?
- 12-16 - You are knocked down, take 3 damage.
- 17+ - You slide roughly to what is now the bottom of the car, but manage to avoid harm.

WHAT DO YOU WANT TO DO?

The car isn't in freefall — it's sliding backward down the main cable toward the mountain. The pace is terrifying but not instantaneous death. They have maybe 30s to try and slow the car or otherwise survive as best as they can. The fog is approaching fast, and while the impact might kill you, the things in the fog definitely will if the car falls too far.

- Climb to the roof or cable, though the car is swinging and the air is freezing thin.
- Brace or anchor the car with climbing gear, ropes, spikes, or magic.
- Slow the fall through creative use of abilities.
- Aid a companion if someone was injured in the initial snap.
- Try to reach the brake on the far (now “top”) side of the car and slow the car a bit (can't stop it).

CRASH!!!

The car hits the mountainside with a deafening crash.

Metal screams. Wood splinters. The world becomes noise and motion — a single, crushing heartbeat of chaos.

You're thrown against the walls, the floor, each other. Cold air rushes in through shattered seams. The smell of oil and blood and ozone fills your lungs.

Then—silence.

You feel weightless for a heartbeat more... then nothing.

CHOSEN



FLASH BACK TO TWO OF THE PARTY (WHOEVER landed lowest on the mountain, if they got clearly separated in the previous scene), living their normal lives, three days ago, blissfully unaware of their impending adventure.

The crash fades.

Sound stretches thin, until even the wind is gone. For a heartbeat, there's only stillness — the echo of impact lingering behind your eyes.

Then another sound rises in its place. Familiar. Softer. You remember the day the letter came.

CHARACTER INTRODUCTIONS

For each the first character, run through the following:

- Where are you, and what are you doing when this morning begins?
- What kind of work or duty usually fills your time here in Stonehollow?
- The messenger arrived yesterday. People have been whispering. What's the mood in town right now?

Do a bit of roleplay with whatever is going on around them. Interact, try to give a spotlight to examine who the character is before the messenger appears:

You've seen the messenger around town these past few days — sharing meals, trading news, laughing quietly with the elders. Now they find you where you work, or rest, or wander.

There's a pause — he examines your face a moment, as if to confirm something. Then the envelope appears, the red wax bright against worn leather.

"Stonehollow has made its choice," he says, with a small smile. "Congratulations, aspirant."

THE MESSENGER, AND THE LETTER

Sir Alaric Vale carries himself with the composure of a man long accustomed to ceremony — and to being watched. His every movement is deliberate: the bow of the head that lingers a heartbeat too long, the stillness between gestures as though he's listening to something no one else can hear.

He's tall and lean, built like a duelist rather than a soldier, his strength in precision rather than force. His formal coat — deep ember red trimmed in black thread — is cut perfectly to his frame, and the brass clasps gleam like captured sunlight. At his throat rests the sigil of the Ember Guard, worn smooth with age; the way he

touches it when he speaks feels half reverence, half reminder.

His hair is close-cropped and dark, showing the faintest silver at the temples. His eyes are pale — gray, almost colorless — and when they meet yours, there's a steadiness that feels both kind and appraising, as though measuring something you can't see. His smile comes easily, but never quite reaches those eyes.

Ask the player the following questions:

- What's the first thing you notice about the letter itself — its seal, the paper, the hand that delivers it?
- Do you open it immediately, or wait until you're alone?
- The letter names you as an aspirant to the Ember Guard. What's your first thought?
- Who or what do you leave behind when you go?

SECOND PC

For the second character, we start a little further into the day, already at work.

- How do you help keep the settlement running? (Work, craft, watch duty, faith, etc.)
- The heads of Stonehollow have been meeting with the messenger. As the messenger approaches, whose name did you think they would choose instead of yours?

Then we go back to the messenger approaching and letter questions. Once the second PC has answered them and is winding down read the following:

The messenger laughs and begins to speak, but the voice sounds far away, indistinct. The memory fades....

FROM THE DEPTHS

{PC 1}, your world returns in fragments — the sting of cold air, the taste of dust, a throbbing ache behind your eyes. The faint hiss of wind. When you open your eyes, the world tilts and rights itself. You're lying amid splintered timbers and twisted metal — the remains of the cable car scattered across the mountainside.

The slope is steep here, broken stone and patches of brittle grass. Jagged ridges rise above, lost quickly in the clouds. Below... a shifting gray tide creeps up the mountain's flank. The Roiling Fog. You can feel it already — a chill on your skin that's more than cold air, a prickle that seems to crawl under your thoughts.

Nearby, {PC 2} stirs — groaning, coughing, checking for wounds. Anything not tied down is gone: packs, supplies... you can't even see enough wreckage to account for the whole cable car. Far below, something rumbles deep within the mist. Then the wind shifts, and you realize the Fog is climbing faster now.

There's no time to linger. You have to climb.

TRACKING THE FOG

Use a 4 segment clock to track how far behind the fog is. It won't catch the players here no matter what, but may start closer or farther from them in the combat encounter depending on how they do.

FIRST CHALLENGE: FINDING A PATH

Medium Intuition Test

- ≤ 11 - As far as you can tell, there is no easy path, this is going to be a scramble no matter where you start. Tick the fog clock and take a bane on the next check.
- 12-16 - You find a path, but the foot of it is a ways off, tick the fog clock.
- 17+ - You find a path, the foot is a ways off, but you think you could jump and catch the ledge directly ahead to save time. Don't tick the clock.

SECOND CHALLENGE: CLIFFSIDE PATH

The mountain path has crumbled away here, leaving only a narrow ledge, slick with condensation.

Easy Agility Test (both characters, once one is across they can assist the other)

- ≤ 11 - You make it across, but the path crumbles behind you - if anyone else needs to make it, they take a bane on their check.
- 12-16 - You make it across.
- 17+ - You make it across quickly - if both players get this result, or if one crits, don't tick the fog clock.

If neither player crits, and they don't both get 17+, tick the fog clock.

THIRD CHALLENGE: CRESTING THE RIDGE

The slope steepens sharply to a stone ridgeline above you. Wind howls across the face, scattering loose stones. The Fog is nearly upon you — only a final push remains.

Medium Might Test (both characters, assist checks from above always succeed)

- ≤ 11 - You reach the ledge, but it crumbles under your fingers sending you falling back down. You're uninjured, but have to spend precious time climbing again, tick the fog clock.
- 12-16 - You scale the ledge, but are pelted with falling pebbles as you climb, take 2 damage.
- 17+ - You scale the ledge safely.

You drag yourself over the edge, lungs burning. The ground levels out beneath your boots — a broad ridge, scattered with dark stone and low scrub. The air is thin but clear here. You see figures lying on the ground ahead.

You recognize them — the other aspirants. It would seem you fell a little further down the mountain than they did. Small movements and groaning would seem to indicate that everyone survived.

As the first couple PCs start helping the others up, we flash back again, this time to the party

{PC 3}, you hear laughter, and the faint thrum of a stringed instrument. The scent of smoke and sweet cider. Light spills across polished wood and bright faces.

You're standing in the Stonehollow town hall, the night before you departed — the sending-off party.

FIRELIGHT AND FAREWELL

Stonehollow has not seen a night like this in years; even the winter solstice celebration pales in comparison. Lanterns hang from every post and tree, their light trembling in the mountain wind. Tables crowd the square, laden with food and casks of amber ale. The air hums with fiddle and drum echoing with Stonehollow's natural acoustics.

It feels as though the whole settlement has turned out — miners still streaked with dust, traders in their traveling coats, even the elders wrapped in heavy shawls against the chill. Voices rise in song, verses half-forgotten but sung loudly anyway.

Near the center, a low platform has been built of fresh-cut pine, garlanded in red and gold ribbon. Not long ago you stood on that stage, {PC 3}, while Cardinal Ephesus' booming voice recited the ceremonial send-off.

Now you stand at its base, surrounded by friends and family. For one more night, there is no fear of the Fog, no thought of the trials ahead. Only pride, and hope, and the firelight's glow reflected in every smiling face.

The goal is to go through the remaining PCs one at a time and give each player a chance to introduce them, and explore the character a little bit. If they have things they want to do/say, GREAT! If not, here are some prompting questions to use:

- What part of the celebration do you find yourself drawn to first — the food, the music, the crowd, or something quieter?
- How do people greet you as you move through the square? With respect? Teasing familiarity? Quiet awe?
- Is there someone here who seems proudest of you — or someone who still doesn't think you should have been chosen?
- Is there someone you think should have been chosen instead of you? Do you seek them out or avoid them at the party?
- As the celebration swells around you, what emotion keeps slipping through the pride — fear, guilt, excitement, disbelief?
- What shared memory do you and another aspirant recall tonight — something that makes you laugh, or something unspoken that passes in silence?
- When you look out west, towards distance Emberglass Peak, what do you imagine waits for you there?
- Who do you feel a need to say goodbye to? How do they react to that farewell?

When switching between PCs, use the opportunity to set the tone some:

- {PC Name}, a burst of laughter rolls through the square as someone drops a whole tray of mugs nearby and is met with mock cheers.
- On the far side of the square, children race past {PC Name} carrying paper lanterns shaped like tiny suns.
- In the distance you see Rathar, the smith, raise a mug of ale towards {Other PC Name} and shout one of his dirty jokes, his grin wide enough to outshine the lanterns.
- (For a PC with a dead NPC) You catch sight of an empty chair at a nearby table, garlanded with a sprig of pine, {PC Name}'s hand resting quietly on it.
- (For a PC who seems hesitant) One of your companions, {PC Name}, stands apart, silhouetted by firelight, lost in thought.

Once everyone has had a chance to introduce their characters, the messenger approaches the group as a whole.

The music has softened to a hum now, conversation breaking into smaller pockets as the night deepens. Lanternlight flickers across mugs raised in toast.

At the edge of one such circle, Sir Alaric Vale stands among you — as if he has been there all along, glass in hand, the firelight catching faintly on the brass clasps of his coat. Someone nearby has just finished a rousing speech in your honor; Alaric's smile follows the applause, measured and polite.

He lifts his glass slightly. "Stonehollow," he says, voice carrying just enough to reach those near him. "Your courage does you proud. The Ember Guard could ask for no finer aspirants."

The toast is brief but genuine-sounding, and a cheer rises around him. As the cheer dies down, Alaric turns his attention back to all of you — curious, attentive. His tone shifts subtly, more personal now.

"You've earned your questions," he says. "Tomorrow you begin a journey few are chosen to make. Ask, and I will answer what I can — about the path, the Guard, or what awaits at Emberglass Peak."

SIR ALARIC VALE

The party at this stage has an opportunity to question Sir Alaric Vale; about their upcoming journey, his experience with the Ember Guard, etc. He answers clearly and openly.

ABOUT THE EMBER GUARD

- The Ember Guard were originally formed by the Emperor as special forces to fight the demons; now they serve the Empress as messengers, problem solvers, and itinerant soldiers.
 - They are often called on/sent out to solve problems across the empire when the existing infrastructure isn't sufficient. (Difficult deliveries, assisting when the local law enforcement is overwhelmed, etc)
 - They are still occasionally called on to aid in repelling demonic forces, and that remains part of their official mission, if one that comes up less often now than it once did.
- Their ranks are small — only about 100-200 in the empire at a time — each chosen only after surviving the Pilgrimage of the Ember.
- They swear their vows before the Flame of Renewal, said to burn at Emberhold (the fortress of the Ember Guard) since the Emperor's ascension.
- Those who complete the journey are changed — not always visibly, but always deeply. "Some say the Flame burns away what is unnecessary."
- The Guard's symbol — the brass sigil at his throat — is centuries old; each member bears one passed down from another who fell in service. "You'll learn of your individual predecessors if and when you reach Emberhold."
- The Guard's strength lies not in numbers, but in unity. "A single ember can die, but together they burn against the dark."

Most answers here feel rehearsed, if the party bothers to check him on any of it. But nothing they can put their fingers on.

ABOUT HIMSELF

- Sir Alaric Vale has been with the Ember Guard for about 20 years now, "longer than I'd like to admit" unless pressed. (lie)
- He's from Ravenroost originally, he took this job in part because it puts him close enough for a visit. (Partial truth, he is from Ravenroost)
- He deflects questions about who bore his emblem before him - supposedly because it's a private matter, but in truth because he doesn't know.

THE JOURNEY AHEAD

- The Aspirant's Path is long, especially from Stonehollow, and they should expect it to take weeks at best (those closer are often asked to visit a more distant settlement first, before making for Emberglass Peak).
- They are expected to make use of whatever paths and travel methods they want. "The Ember Guard doesn't ask you to take any unnecessary risks by choosing a more difficult path. The mountains are dangerous enough without that."
- He suggests that they not try to rush and make the cable car in the first day. "The journey is long. Pace yourselves. There is an old watch station, spartan, but dry, on the far side of the Cable Car run. If you make it there for your second night, the third can be spent comfortably in Dimdale."
- "From Dimdale you'll continue west to Stormcradle; the stretch from there to Starwatch Hold is probably the hardest bit. Definitely the longest without the opportunity to sleep in a real bed!"
- "I overheard someone in Dimdale mention a leak, though hopefully they'll have taken care of it by the time you get there." (Use this as an opportunity to explain to the players that Dimdale is below "high tide", and relies on barrier walls and high ridgelines to protect the valley city)

If the party watches closely, his behavior is mostly normal, though he refuses all alcoholic drinks, and seems slightly more tense when asked questions about the Emperor or Empress.

When the party is done, someone nearby tells a joke and Sir Alaric laughs, then read the following.

The laughter lingers a heartbeat too long — then slips away. In its place, you hear a voice, distant but urgent. Someone calling your name — {PC 1 or 2}, you think — muffled, fading, pulling you toward it.

Light bends, colors drain, and the warmth of the hall collapses into gray and cold. The sound of celebration becomes the hiss of wind through broken stone.

You find yourself lying at the bottom of a steep hill near a mountain ridge, {PC 1 or 2} bent over to help you up.

DEMONS!



HE PARTY HAS A FEW MOMENTS TO HELP EACH other off, dust themselves off, and look around before the Fog, and the Demons within it, catch up with them.

For a few heartbeats, there's only the wind. It snakes over the ridge, tugging at cloaks and scattering loose stones down the slope. The others are stirring now — coughing, swearing, checking for wounds. The air is thin and sharp, tasting faintly of iron.

Then the world goes quiet. Even the wind seems to hold its breath.

The Fog reaches the ridge like a living thing, tendrils rolling over the stone — pale gray at first, then bruised green beneath, pulsing faintly from within. A low chittering sound rises out of it, thin and insectile, quickly swelling into a hundred overlapping whispers.

Shapes burst from the haze — small, skittering, too fast to count. Their eyes gleam a sickly emerald as they scuttle on clawed limbs, half-rat, half-insect, bile dripping from their maws. The stench hits like rot and acid.

A wave of pitlings and ensnarers swarm forward, screeching and vomiting streams of burning phlegm. Behind them, {a heavier shape/heavier shapes} lurch into view — (a) twisted mass(es) of muscle and mouths, their body(s) slick with venomous slime. Long barbed tongues lash out, hooking stone and flesh alike.

The Fog surges again, climbing the hill towards you nearly as fast as the charging demons. Draw Steel!

The party is attacked by a horde of demons:

For 3 PCs, 8 Pitlings, 12 Ensnarers, 1 Muceron

For 4th, add 4 Pitlings and 4 Ensnarers

For 5th, add 4 Pitlings and 1 Muceron

The battlemat either needs to be quite long, or else have obstacles I can move along it to simulate that length. The fight will be a running one, with the fog rising 4 squares towards them per round. It starts 8 squares away, -1 for each tick on the clock.

The fog can be driven back with wind or fire abilities; either can clear it in a 2-3 square burst around the impact. If a hero is caught within the fog at the start of their turn they take 3 corruption damage.

The fog will only advance for 4 rounds, after which it reaches “High Tide” and stops, though the demons make no such concession.

A BREIF MOMENT OF RESPITE

Once the party emerges victorious, they have a moment to recover and discuss.

The last of the creatures falls, dissolving into a smear of dark ichor that sizzles against the rock. For a moment, there's only the ragged sound of breathing — your own, and that of your companions.

Then you realize the Fog has stopped. The gray tide below no longer climbs, its edge pulsing faintly like a spent heartbeat. The air still stinks of bile and sulfur, but the mountain itself seems to exhale, the pressure easing.

You've survived. For now.

Given a moment to think, it's strange — the demons shouldn't have come this close to the edge of the Fog, let alone chased you out of it. And cable cars don't just fail like that, you can count on one hand the stories of failures like that in the past hundred years across the entire Empire.

The wind returns, thin and cold, carrying the faint rattle of the broken cable draped across the cliffs above you. Whatever answers there are lie ahead — and further from the Fog's reach.

They also notice that most of their gear, anything that wasn't attached to them before the crash, is lost, presumably in the cable car. When they're ready to move on, they climb a short ways before discovering the cable draped against the mountain. They can use it to climb, or just as a point of reference to follow back to the pass.

CABLEWRIGHT

As you continue your climb, the wind begins carries a strange sound — a low, irregular hum, almost like a song cut short. When you glance upslope, you see the source: a wrecked cable car clinging to the side of the mountain, half-suspended by the tangled remnants of the broken line.

Sparks flicker along the twisted cables, tiny bursts of blue-white light that dance against the gray stone. Smoke rises in thin curls from cracked panels and a faint, acrid smell cuts through the mountain air — burning oil and ozone.

The car is smaller than the one you rode, built for a single passenger. Brass fittings glint beneath the soot, and you can just make out the symbol of the Cablewrights' Guild stamped along one side. It must be a cablewright's maintenance car — the kind used to inspect the lines.

It's lodged about fifty feet away across a sheer rock face, with no obvious path from here. The slope between is broken and treacherous, scattered with loose shale and patches of ice. You'd need to climb carefully to reach it... if you choose to.

Crossing is a easy agility group check by default:

- ≤ 11 - One of you loses your footing and slides several feet; whoever falls and whoever helps them are busy trying to get everyone back together while the others investigate the wreck.
- 12-16 - You make steady progress, but your arms are burning by the time you all reach the other side, and stones clatter below you. You're beyond the reach of the demons for now, but who knows what else might have heard that...
- 17+ - The climb is treacherous, but you all make it without issue.

The climb ends at a narrow ledge, half-swallowed by smoke. The maintenance car hangs at an angle, one corner wedged into the rock, the other suspended over open air by a single groaning cable. The air hums faintly with residual magic, the smell of ozone sharp and metallic in your throat.

Inside, shattered crystal lenses spark fitfully among the wreckage of tools and brass fittings. A figure lies slumped against the far wall — the cablewright, judging by the soot-streaked guild jacket and the shattered scrying lens still strapped to one arm. Their breathing is shallow, uneven.

As you draw closer, they stir — a reflexive flinch, then a moan. The car shudders again, a deep metallic groan from somewhere beneath. Whatever holds it here won't last forever.

The party is able to pull the engineer out without difficulty, but unless they try (and succeed) at something clever, the car falls shortly after they get her out. She is a middle-aged dwarven woman in her engineer's work-garb.

An easy Reason check can help bring the engineer back to consciousness:

- ≤ 11 - The engineer is stabilized, but does not regain consciousness. Hauling her up the mountain is going to suck....
- 12-16 - The engineer regains consciousness.
- 17+ - The engineer regains consciousness, and is still wearing her pack of emergency climbing gear.

WHAT THE CABLEWRIGHT KNOWS

- Her name is Vinn Berghish.
- She has been working the Dimdale-Stonehollow line for about 4 years, and been an engineer for most of her adult life.
- A routine scrying examination revealed something strange on the line, about 3/4 of the way to Stonehollow.
- She took the car out to examine it up close, but the line broke before she got there.
- As of the previous detailed inspection the line was in perfect condition - she's proud of this, and offended greatly if it's suggested the failure might be her fault in any way.

Assuming the party manages to avoid offending Vinn, and social tests that come up with her are made with a double boon after saving her life. If they openly suggest the failure might be her fault and don't immediately recant they take a bane instead.

If conscious, she will ask for help getting the rest of the way up the mountain. The remaining climb is a group Might check. If they crossed to the car they can use the cable to climb, giving them a boon. If they found Vinn and either she or they managed to get the climbing gear out of the pack they get another boon.

- ≤ 11 - You make it up, but by the time you get there you're ragged, your clothes are a mess, and you'll be taking a bane on social checks until you can get cleaned up. (Not with Vinn)
- 12-16 - You make it up to the top.
- 17+ - You make it up to the top, and find some of your lost gear along the way!

AIR THIN, HEARTS STEADY

The slope evens out at last, giving way to a narrow plateau carved into the mountainside. Ahead, three stone pillars rise to support a simple pavilion — the upper terminal of the cable line. Its roof groans in the wind, wooden shingles creaking, and the boarding platform juts over the drop like a tongue of weathered planks.

The cable itself hangs slack over the chasm, its far end vanishing into the gray distance below. The faint smell of ozone still clings to the air, sharper here, like burned copper.

Beside the pavilion stands a squat stone house with heavy shutters and a tall chimney: the cablewright's quarters, attached to the winch room. The great drum and gears within are still and silent.

To the west, a narrow footpath winds along the ridgeline — a pale thread leading toward distant Dimdale, a small line of smoke from fires rising into the sky. For the first time since the crash, the wind carries no trace of the Fog's hiss below. Only the soft, endless murmur of the peaks.

If the party chooses to investigate the winch/mechanism they can discover:

- The winch appears to be in perfect working order and mostly undamaged (some minor damage can safely be attributed to the sudden release of the cable from the far side).
 - Vinn will confirm this if she's with the party - the problem was definitely either on the far side, or somewhere along the cable itself.
- If Vinn is with them, she wants to pop into her home to report the cable failure (she has magical means of communicating the status of the line).
- The party can try a medium Reason test to use the winch to pull the cable up.
 - If Vinn is with them they can skip the test and she auto succeeds at it if prompted.
 - If they succeed the noise is immense as it shakes off the remnants of the cars, but it does come up.
 - The end of the cable has half a runic circle around it, sliced clean through in a perfect line, much like the end of the cable itself.
 - An appropriate lore check will reveal that the runes were configured to wait for the car to cross, then sever the line.

If Vinn is with the party, she'll want to continue with them to Dimdale once she's sent her status update. She can communicate the status of the line from here, but she'll need to go get help to repair the line.

HIKING TO DIMDALE

The rest of the trip to Dimdale is uneventful. The party can chat on the way if they want, or we can skip straight to their arrival.

The mountain path from the terminal winds westward, narrow but well-trodden. The climb eases at last, replaced by rolling stretches of stone and hardy brush. Here and there, frost-crustured cairns mark the way — each built by travelers who made the same journey long before you.

The Fog below is still, a gray ocean spread across the valleys. From this height it looks almost peaceful, its true nature hidden by distance. The wind tastes cleaner here, carrying only the faint scent of pine and the smoke of distant hearthfires.

Hours pass in a rhythm of boots on stone and the slow burn of tired muscles. Overhead, the clouds thin enough to reveal a wash of pale sunlight across the peaks. The ridges ahead gleam faintly with the reflected lights from Dimdale.

As you walk, the sound of your own thoughts — and those of your companions — becomes impossible to ignore.

- When the silence stretches too long, who breaks it first, and what do they say?
- After everything you've seen — the Fog, the demons, the crash — what part of it is still replaying in your head?
- You've survived what should've killed you. How do you feel about that — relieved, proud, or quietly unnerved?
- The air here feels different, lighter somehow. What do you notice for the first time now that you're not running or climbing?
- The cairns that line the path are said to bring luck if you add a stone. Who does, and what silent thought accompanies the gesture?
- If Vinn is with the party, she keeps glancing back toward the line's direction. What question do you ask her about her work or the mountain?
- Someone wonders aloud if the sabotage was meant for you — or if you were just in the wrong car. How does that land?